

Chapter Four

The Weight That Stayed

Nora returned to herself with Adam's grief still inside her.

That was the first thing she understood.

Not where she was. Not how much time had passed. Not why the world had pulled her out of one body and thrown her back into another.

Only this:

The grief had followed.

She came back on the riverbank with her cheek pressed against cold stone and her phone buzzing somewhere near her hand. For a few seconds, she could not move. Her body was hers again, but it felt unfamiliar, as if she had borrowed it too.

Her chest rose too quickly.

Her fingers scraped against the pavement.

The air smelled of wet leaves, river water, and distant smoke.

"Nora?"

Adam's voice came from the fallen phone.

Small.

Tinny.

Afraid.

She reached for it with shaking hands.

"Nora, please answer me."

She pressed the phone to her ear. "I'm here."

His breath broke. "What happened? You stopped talking. I heard something fall."

“I dropped the phone.”

“Are you hurt?”

“No.”

It was almost true.

“Nora.”

She closed her eyes.

She could still feel him.

Not metaphorically. Not as a memory. Adam’s emotions lingered beneath her skin like a second pulse. Fear. Exhaustion. Love so careful it hurt. And behind it, Maya’s voice from the hospital waiting room.

My father’s cancer is back.

Nora swallowed hard.

She had been wrong.

Not partly wrong. Not understandably wrong.

Wrong in the ugliest way.

“Nora,” Adam said again, quieter now. “Talk to me.”

She opened her eyes.

Across the river, windows glowed in buildings she did not know. People moved behind them, framed in warm rectangles of light, carrying cups, closing curtains, living private lives Nora had no right to enter.

“I know,” she whispered.

Adam went silent.

“What do you know?”

“Maya’s father.”

Another silence.

This one changed everything.

When Adam spoke again, his voice had lowered. “Did she tell you?”

“No.”

“Then how?”

Nora looked down at her hand. Her fingers were trembling so badly the phone knocked softly against her cheek.

“I can’t explain it.”

“You need to try.”

“I can’t.”

“Nora, you accused her. You accused both of us. If you know now, then you need to tell me how.”

His voice was not angry.

That made it worse.

He sounded like a man trying to stay calm while the floor cracked beneath him.

Nora pushed herself upright. A cyclist passed and glanced at her, then continued. She must have looked drunk or ill, sitting on the ground by the river with her hair wind-tangled and her face wet.

“I didn’t mean to hurt her,” Nora said.

“I know.”

“No, you don’t.” Her voice shook. “I really didn’t.”

“I believe you.”

She almost laughed.

That was Adam. Still trying to give her a safe place to stand, even after she had made herself unsafe.

“She asked you not to tell me because she thought I would try to carry it for her,” Nora said.

“Yes.”

“And she was right.”

Adam exhaled.

The sound was soft, defeated.

“She was afraid,” he said. “Her father didn’t want many people to know yet. Maya was trying to respect that. And she was trying to protect you.”

“From what?”

“From becoming responsible for pain that was not yours to fix.”

The sentence settled between them.

Nora looked at the river.

Pain that was not yours to fix.

She wanted to reject it. To say love meant helping, meant carrying, meant refusing to let anyone suffer alone.

But hadn’t she turned Maya’s pain into evidence? Hadn’t she taken something private and forced it to become about herself?

Her throat tightened.

“I need to see her.”

“I don’t think that’s a good idea tonight.”

“She hates me.”

“She doesn’t.”

“You didn’t hear her.”

“I did,” Adam said gently. “She called me crying, remember?”

Nora flinched.

“I need to apologize.”

“You do. But not while you’re like this.”

“Like what?”

“Terrified.”

She hated how quickly he found the truth.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Then Adam said, “Where are you?”

Nora looked around. “By the river. Near the bridge.”

“I’m coming.”

“No.”

“Nora.”

“No, Adam. Please.”

The word stopped him.

She heard it happen. The way he swallowed his instinct to act. To fix. To arrive with warm hands and careful questions.

“Okay,” he said.

That obedience hurt more than pressure would have.

“I need to go home,” Nora said. “Alone.”

“Text me when you get there.”

“I will.”

“And Nora?”

She closed her eyes. “Yes?”

“Whatever is happening to you, hiding it is going to make it worse.”

She did not answer.

Because they both knew he was right.

Nora walked home with Adam's grief still moving inside her.

It did not fade the way emotions were supposed to fade. It stayed beneath her own thoughts, coloring them. When she passed a pharmacy, she remembered the smell of hospital disinfectant. When a man laughed into his phone, she felt Adam's exhaustion again, the particular ache of wanting to protect two people and failing both.

By the time she reached her apartment, she was no longer sure where her guilt ended and Adam's began.

That frightened her almost as much as the jump itself.

Inside, the apartment looked exactly as she had left it.

Coffee cup in the sink.

Blanket folded over the couch.

A book lying open on the table, face down, its spine bent.

Ordinary things.

Proof that life could remain still while the person inside it changed completely.

Nora locked the door and leaned against it.

Then she slid down to the floor and cried.

She cried for Maya, who had been carrying her father's illness in silence. She cried for Adam, awake in the dark with tears he would not let fall. She cried for herself, though that felt selfish. Mostly, she cried because the world had become too porous. Other people's pain could enter her now. Their memories could open inside her. Their secrets could arrive without consent.

And yet she was still capable of misunderstanding everything.

That was the cruelest part.

The body-jumps did not make her wiser.

They only made her closer.

Closeness, she was beginning to understand, was not the same as truth.

Her phone buzzed.

Maya.

Nora froze.

For several seconds, she could only stare.

Then she opened the message.

Adam told me you know.

Nora's stomach twisted.

Another message arrived.

I'm not ready to talk tonight.

Then:

But I don't hate you.

Nora covered her mouth with one hand.

The mercy of it almost broke her.

She typed slowly, deleting every sentence that tried to explain too much.

I'm sorry.

It was too small.

She added:

I made your pain about my fear. I'm so sorry.

She stared at the message until the words blurred.

Then she sent it.

Maya did not answer for several minutes.

When she finally did, her reply was short.

I know.

Nora did not know whether it meant I know you are sorry or I know what you did.

Maybe both.

She set the phone down and pressed her palms against her knees.

The apartment hummed quietly around her.

For the first time since the first jump, Nora tried to think about the impossible thing itself.

Not Maya.

Not Adam.

The jumps.

There had been two now. Maya first. Then Adam.

Both connected to the same secret.

Both people she loved.

Both moments of emotional intensity.

Was that the pattern?

Fear.

Closeness.

A hidden truth.

The thought made her cold.

If the jumps were drawn to secrets, then every person she loved had become a locked room she might be forced into.

And if they were drawn to fear, then Nora herself might be the key.

She stood too quickly and went to the bathroom.

The mirror above the sink caught her face in harsh light. She looked pale and hollow-eyed. Her hair was tangled around her cheeks. There was dirt on one sleeve from the riverbank.

She looked like someone who had survived something.

Or someone beginning to disappear.

“Nora,” she whispered to the reflection.

Her own name sounded like a test.

She gripped the sink.

“I am Nora Reyes.”

The reflection stared back.

“I am twenty-seven years old.”

Her voice shook.

“I live alone. I am engaged to Adam Cruz. Maya Santos is my sister.”

Chosen sister, she almost corrected.

But the distinction felt meaningless now. Love had made Maya family long before language did.

“I am in my own body.”

She waited.

Nothing changed.

The mirror remained a mirror.

Her hands remained her hands.

A laugh escaped her, sharp and humorless.

Then the light above her flickered.

Nora stopped breathing.

The flicker came again.

Once.

Twice.

The bathroom stretched at the edges.

“No,” she said.

The word was barely sound.

Pressure gathered behind her eyes.

She backed away from the sink, hitting the towel rack with her elbow.

“No, no, no.”

The mirror blurred.

For a heartbeat, her reflection changed.

Not fully.

Just enough.

The face in the glass was not hers.

Older. Male. Unshaven. Eyes red with exhaustion.

Then the bathroom vanished.

Nora was standing behind a counter.

Bright fluorescent lights buzzed overhead. A scanner beeped. Plastic bags rustled. Somewhere nearby, a child was crying because someone had refused him candy.

Her hands were large and rough, resting on a conveyor belt.

Not her hands.

Again.

Panic rose, but this time it collided with something else.

Boredom.

Irritation.

A dull ache in the lower back.

She was inside a man she did not know.

He wore a blue vest with a name tag pinned to it.

DANIEL.

For one strange second, the name hit her like a private joke.

Daniel was her brother's name.

But this was not her brother.

This Daniel was older, heavier in the shoulders, with rough palms and tired eyes reflected faintly in the dark register screen.

A customer stood in front of him, unloading groceries too slowly. Apples. Pasta. Milk. A cheap bottle of wine. The customer's face was tight with the kind of impatience people mistook for importance.

Nora tried to move.

Daniel's body did not obey her.

He scanned the apples.

Beep.

The pasta.

Beep.

The milk.

Beep.

The customer sighed loudly.

Daniel's jaw tightened.

Not now, he thought.

The thought entered Nora cleanly, without warning.

Not now. Just get through the shift. Don't think about the letter.
Don't think about rent. Don't think about Sophie asking why Mom
isn't coming home.

The emotions came next.

Fear.

Shame.

Fatigue so deep it felt physical.

Nora reeled inside him.

This was not Maya.

This was not Adam.

This was a stranger.

Daniel picked up the wine bottle. His wrist hurt when he twisted it
toward the scanner.

The customer tapped a card against the machine before the total
appeared.

"Can you hurry?" she asked.

Daniel smiled.

It was automatic. Practiced. Empty.

"Of course."

Inside him, something burned.

Nora felt the humiliation of needing politeness from people who
did not see him. She felt the math running constantly beneath his

thoughts. Rent. Medicine. Groceries. Late fee. Daughter's shoes.
Letter from the landlord. Call from the hospital.

The hospital.

The word struck Nora so hard she nearly lost the thread of him.

Hospital again.

Daniel handed the receipt to the customer. She took it without
looking at him.

Then a child's voice called from somewhere behind him.

"Dad?"

Daniel turned.

A little girl stood near the end of the counter, wearing a pink coat
with one missing button. Her hair was in two uneven braids. She
held a drawing in both hands.

A woman beside her looked embarrassed. "Sorry. She ran ahead."

Daniel's whole body softened.

His exhaustion changed shape.

Love entered so suddenly that Nora almost cried from the force of
it.

"Sophie," he said. "What are you doing here?"

The girl lifted the drawing.

"It's for Mom."

The world inside Daniel broke.

Not loudly.

Not in a way anyone in the shop could see.

But Nora felt the fracture.

A hospital bed.

A woman sleeping beneath thin blankets.

A doctor's voice saying, "We are doing everything we can."

Sophie asking, "When can Mom come home?"

Daniel's lie: "Soon."

The memory closed.

Nora returned to the checkout counter, trapped inside the private grief of a man buying time with smiles.

And for the first time, the jump had nothing to do with her.

That should have comforted her.

Instead it terrified her.

Because it meant there was no border.

No rule she understood.

No promise that the next life she entered would belong to someone she loved, or someone safe, or someone whose pain she could survive.

Daniel bent down and took the drawing from his daughter.

"It's beautiful," he whispered.

Sophie smiled.

The light above the counter flickered.

The scanner beeped once by itself.

Then the grocery store folded into white.

Nora came back on the bathroom floor.

Her shoulder hurt.

Her cheek was wet.

The light above the mirror was steady again.

For a long moment, she did not move.

Then she crawled to the toilet and threw up.

When it was over, she sat with her back against the bathtub, shaking.

Maya's grief.

Adam's love.

Daniel's fear.

All of it remained.

Not completely. Not enough to become memory in the ordinary way. But enough to leave fingerprints.

Nora pressed both hands to her chest.

She had thought the danger was that she might uncover secrets.

She had been wrong.

The danger was that every life she entered left something behind.

And she did not know how many borrowed sorrows a person could carry before they stopped recognizing their own.